

Truce under fire: On the first phase of the Israel-Hamas ceasefire

All sides must ensure that the war in Gaza ends permanently

As the first phase of the Israel-Hamas **ceasefire comes to an end** on Saturday (March 1, 2025), there are growing signs that the already **fragile truce** is under **enormous strain**. When the deal was reached in mid-January, the understanding was that it would be implemented in three phases. In the first, Israel was required to **reposition** some of its **troops**, **letting displaced** Palestinians move from the south to the north, and release more than a thousand security **prisoners** in return for some 32 **hostages**. In the second phase, both sides are required to bring the war to an end, while the third phase is about the reconstruction of Gaza. In the first 42 days, both sides **stuck to** their **commitments** despite challenges — Hamas released 38 hostages and Israel freed hundreds of prisoners. **Talks** for the second phase **were** to begin days earlier — Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu sent a **delegation** to Cairo only on Thursday (February 27, 2025). And, according to the deal, Israel was to complete the **withdrawal** of its troops from the Philadelphi corridor, the 14-kilometre **stretch** along southern Gaza's border with Egypt, by Saturday. But on Thursday, an Israeli soldier **ruled out** an Israeli **pull back** from the corridor, **casting doubts on** the future of the ceasefire.

When Israel launched the war on Gaza, **following** Hamas's October 7, 2023 cross-border attack in which 1,200 people were killed, Mr. Netanyahu's declared objectives were the **dismantling** of Hamas and the release of the hostages. But after 15 months of war, in which nearly 48,000 Palestinians have been killed and more than 1,00,000 **wounded**, Israel achieved neither of the goals, which **eventually** forced Mr. Netanyahu to **strike a deal** with Hamas to get the hostages out. For a permanent end of the war, Israel has to leave Gaza. If Mr. Netanyahu withdraws his troops, Hamas will remain in power in the **enclave**, an outcome that could **lead to** the **collapse** of his right-religious government. The **proposal** by United States President Donald Trump to "own Gaza" and **ethnically cleanse** the strip's 2.3 million Palestinians **seems** to have **hardened** Israel's position further. But by keeping its troops in Gaza, Israel is not only **violating** the terms of the ceasefire but is also stepping into the **abyss**. Despite its superior forces and unmatched fire power, Israel has failed to destroy Hamas, which, in the words of Israel Defense Forces spokesperson Daniel Hagari, is "rooted in the hearts" of Palestinians. After the first phase of the ceasefire, Hamas will still have over 60 hostages. So, if Israel refuses to exit Gaza and extend the ceasefire, what is awaiting the enclave is **a war of attrition**. Instead, the Jewish state should **honour** its commitments under the agreement. **The U.S.**, rather than make **outlandish** statements such as ethnically cleansing Palestinians, **should** use its **leverage** over Israel and its Arab neighbours to implement the ceasefire and draw up a plan for post-war Gaza, that includes its **governance** and **reconstruction**.

[Practice Exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

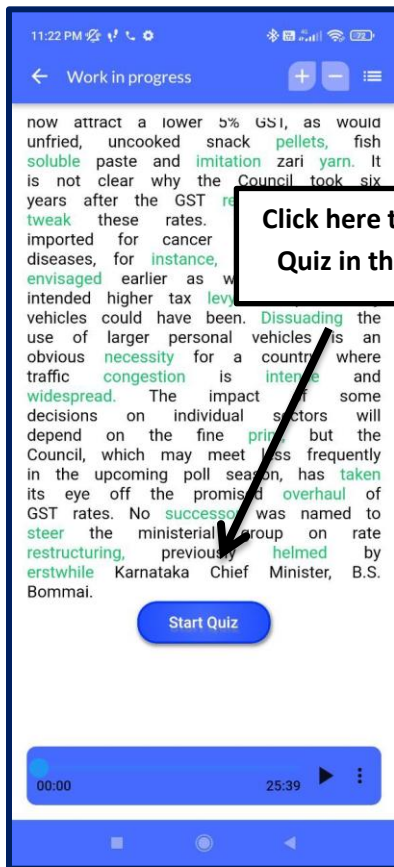
1. **Ceasefire** (noun) – Truce, Armistice, Peace agreement, Suspension, Cessation
युद्धविराम
2. **Come to an end** (phrase) – Conclude, Finish, Terminate, Expire, Cease समाप्त होना
3. **Fragile** (adjective) – Delicate, Weak, Vulnerable, Brittle, Unstable नाजुक
4. **Truce** (noun) – Ceasefire, Armistice, Peace, Agreement, Pause संघर्षविराम
5. **Enormous** (adjective) – Huge, Massive, Vast, Immense, Gigantic विशाल
6. **Strain** (noun) – Pressure, Tension, Stress, Burden, Load तनाव
7. **Reposition** (noun) – Relocate, Move, Shift, Rearrange, Adjust पुनः स्थापित करना
8. **Troop** (noun) – Soldiers, Forces, Army, Unit, Battalion सैनिक
9. **Let** (verb) – Allow, Permit, Enable, Authorize, Grant होने देना
10. **Displaced** (adjective) – Uprooted, Evicted, Homeless, Relocated, Exiled विस्थापित
11. **Prisoner** (noun) – Captive, Detainee, Inmate, Hostage, Convict कैदी
12. **Hostage** (noun) – Captive, Prisoner, Pawn, Detainee, Victim बंधक
13. **Stick** (to) (verb) – Adhere, Abide, Follow, Comply, Persist पर टिके रहना
14. **Commitment** (noun) – Promise, Pledge, Obligation, Dedication, Assurance प्रतिबद्धता
15. **Delegation** (noun) – Team, Mission, Envoy, Deputation, Representatives प्रतिनिधिमंडल
16. **Withdrawal** (noun) – Retreat, Pullout, Removal, Evacuation, Exit वापसी
17. **Stretch** (noun) – Extent, Span, Length, Area, Distance फैलाव/ क्षेत्र
18. **Rule out** (phrasal verb) – Exclude, Eliminate, Reject, Dismiss, Discard खारिज करना
19. **Pull back** (phrasal verb) – Retreat, Withdraw, Recede, Fall back, Move back पीछे हटना
20. **Cast doubt on** (phrase) – Question, Challenge, Dispute, Suspect, Distrust संदेह पैदा करना
21. **Following** (preposition) – After, Subsequent to, In the wake of, Post, Behind के बाद
22. **Dismantling** (noun) – Disassembly, Demolition, Destruction, Deconstruction, Breakdown विखंडन

23. **Wound** (verb) – Injure, Hurt, Harm, Damage, Scar घायल करना
24. **Eventually** (adverb) – Finally, Ultimately, In time, Sooner or later, At last अंततः
25. **Strike a deal** (phrase) – Negotiate, Agree, Settle, Bargain, Contract समझौता करना
26. **Enclave** (noun) – Territory, Zone, Region, District, Area क्षेत्र
27. **Lead** (to) (verb) – Cause, Result in, Bring about, Produce, Trigger वजह बनना
28. **Collapse** (noun) – Failure, Breakdown, Ruin, Fall, Crumbling पतन
29. **Ethnically cleanse** (noun) – the organized, often violent attempt by a particular cultural or racial group to completely remove from a country or area all members of a different group जातीय सफाई
30. **Harden** (verb) – Strengthen, Toughen, Solidify, Intensify, Fortify कठोर बनाना
31. **Violate** (verb) – Breach, Infringe, Break, Disobey, Defy उल्लंघन करना
32. **Abyss** (noun) – Chasm, Void, Gulf, Pit, Depth गहराई
33. **War of attrition** (noun) – a war that is fought over a long period and only ends when one side has neither the soldiers and equipment nor the determination left to continue fighting
34. **Honour** (verb) – to do what you have agreed or promised वादे को पूरा करना
35. **Outlandish** (adjective) – Bizarre, Strange, Weird, Unusual, Eccentric विचित्र
36. **Leverage** (noun) – Influence, Power, Advantage, Control, Clout प्रभाव
37. **Governance** (noun) – Administration, Management, Rule, Control, Leadership शासन
38. **Reconstruction** (noun) – Rebuilding, Restoration, Renewal, Rehabilitation, Revival पुनर्निर्माण

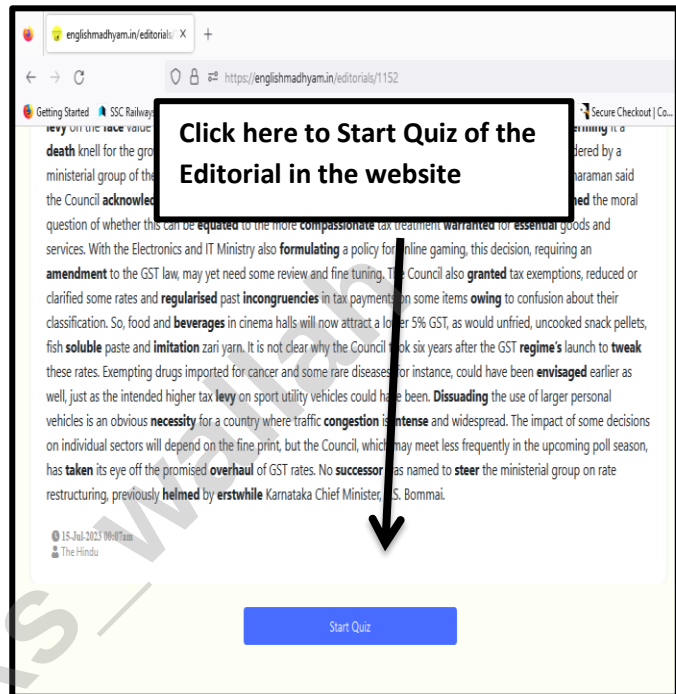
Summary of the Editorial

1. **Fragile Ceasefire:** The first phase of the Israel-Hamas ceasefire, ending on March 1, 2025, is under strain, with doubts about its continuation.
2. **Three-Phase Plan:** The ceasefire agreement includes three phases: troop repositioning and prisoner-hostage exchanges, ending the war, and Gaza's reconstruction.
3. **First Phase Progress:** In the first 42 days, Hamas released 38 hostages, and Israel freed hundreds of prisoners, but challenges remain.
4. **Troop Withdrawal Delay:** Israel's failure to withdraw from the Philadelphi corridor by the deadline casts doubt on the ceasefire's future.
5. **War Objectives Unmet:** After 15 months of war, Israel has not achieved its goals of dismantling Hamas or fully securing hostage releases.
6. **Human Cost:** Nearly 48,000 Palestinians have been killed, and over 100,000 wounded, highlighting the war's devastating impact.
7. **Political Dilemma:** Withdrawing troops could leave Hamas in power, risking the collapse of Netanyahu's government.
8. **US Proposal:** Donald Trump's suggestion to "own Gaza" and ethnically cleanse Palestinians has hardened Israel's stance.
9. **Violation of Terms:** Israel's refusal to withdraw troops violates the ceasefire agreement and risks prolonging the conflict.
10. **Hamas Resilience:** Despite Israel's military superiority, Hamas remains deeply rooted among Palestinians, as acknowledged by Israeli officials.
11. **Hostage Situation:** Hamas still holds over 60 hostages, complicating negotiations for a permanent ceasefire.
12. **Risk of Attrition:** If Israel refuses to extend the ceasefire, Gaza faces a prolonged war of attrition.
13. **US Role:** The US should use its influence to ensure ceasefire implementation and support Gaza's post-war governance and reconstruction.
14. **Need for Diplomacy:** A diplomatic solution, rather than military escalation, is essential for lasting peace.
15. **Reconstruction Plan:** A comprehensive plan for Gaza's governance and reconstruction is crucial to prevent future conflicts.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



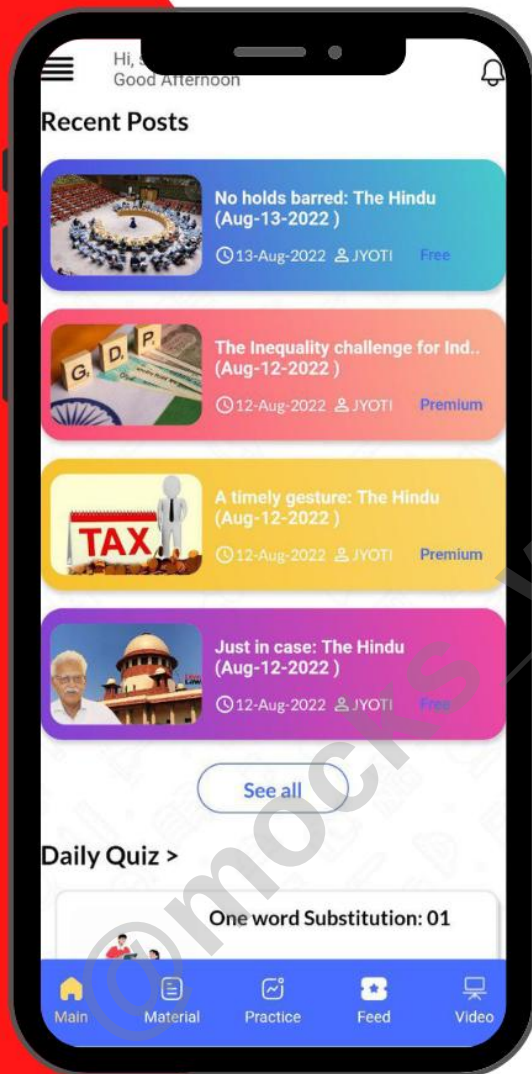
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